JIEE ZHONG

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Miami University | Department of Economics | Oxford, OH 45056-9536

EMPLOYMENT

Assistant Professor of Economics, Miami University, 2024 - Present

PROFESSIONAL APPOINTMENTS

Research Affiliate, Institute of Labor Economics (IZA), 2026 - Present

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Economics, Texas A&M University, May 2024

M.A., Economics, Xiamen University, June 2018

B.A., Taxation, Guangdong University of Foreign Studies, June 2013

RESEARCH FIELDS

Education Economics, Labor Economics, Environmental Economics, and Health Economics

PUBLICATIONS

"Early Grade Retention Harms Adult Earnings" [Pre-Publication Version]

American Economic Journal: Applied Economics (2026).

This paper provides new causal evidence on the effects of grade retention on educational attainment, behavioral outcomes, and labor market performance by analyzing Texas's reading test-based retention policy. Using a fuzzy regression discontinuity design, I find that third-grade retention significantly reduces annual earnings at age 26 by $3,477 (19%). While temporarily improving test scores, retention increases absenteeism, violent behavior, and juvenile crime, and reduces the likelihood of high school graduation. Moreover, retained students exhibit higher community college enrollment but lower public university attendance, though neither estimate is statistically significant.

"Can Social Media Rhetoric Incite Hate Incidents? Evidence from Trump's "Chinese Virus" Tweets" [Pre-Publication Version]

Journal of Urban Economics (2023). Joint with Andy Cao and Jason Lindo.

We investigate whether Donald Trump's "Chinese Virus" tweets contributed to the rise of anti-Asian incidents. We find that the number of incidents spiked following Trump's initial "Chinese Virus" tweets and the subsequent dramatic rise in internet search activity for the phrase. Difference-in-differences and event-study analyses leveraging spatial variation indicate that this spike in anti-Asian incidents was significantly more pronounced in counties that supported Donald Trump in the 2016 presidential election relative to those that supported Hillary Clinton. We estimate that anti-Asian incidents spiked by approximately 4200 percent in Trump-supported counties compared to an increase of approximately 200 percent in Clinton-supported counties.

HANDBOOK CHAPTER PUBLICATION

Kennedy, K., ter Meulen, S., & Zhong, J. (2026). Grade retention. In K. F. Zimmermann (Ed.), *Handbook of Labor, Human Resources and Population Economics*. Springer, Cham. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-57365-6_458-1

Grade retention is widely practiced in education systems worldwide, but the effects of grade retention often differ from those of typical educational attainment. This chapter discusses recent research on the causes and consequences of grade retention, covering the effects of grade retention on academic achievement, behavioral

outcomes, and labor market outcomes. Furthermore, it also provides an overview of the estimation of the effects of grade retention and a discussion of how retention can affect other research on education and labor markets. Finally, it provides an overview of research on the incentive effects of grade retention policies on retained and non-retained students and makes suggestions for future work in this area.

WORKING PAPERS

"Do State-Funded Pre-K Programs Improve Long-Run Outcomes?"[IZA DP No. 18790] (Joint with Maya Mikdash)

We study the long-term effects of access to state-funded early childhood education on educational attainment and labor market outcomes. To do so, we exploit quasi-random variation across districts and cohorts generated by the phased rollout of Texas's large-scale public Pre-K program. Using restricted-access administrative data, we find that access to state-funded Pre-K substantially increases enrollment, particularly in districts without alternative preschool options. Additional results show that in districts that provide Pre-K simultaneously for three- and four-year-olds, access to Pre-K increases earnings at age 27 and high-school graduation by about 4 percent, with no effect on college enrollment. In contrast, access to Pre-K has no effects on labor market and educational outcomes in districts that primarily serve four-year-olds only. We provide suggestive evidence that the effectiveness of state-funded Pre-K depends on program funding rather than access alone.

"Low-Level Lead Exposure and Children's Human Capital: Evidence from Piston-Engine Aircraft" (Joint with Thao Duong)

How harmful are low levels of lead exposure to children's human capital development? We study this question using the sharp increase in piston-engine aircraft activity after 2007 and longitudinal administrative records linking Texas students from elementary school to adulthood. A triple-differences design shows that increased piston-engine aircraft activity and associated lead emissions lower reading achievement, reduce high school graduation and college enrollment, and suggestively lower early-career earnings. Our findings provide causal evidence that even contemporary low-level lead exposure generates persistent losses in human capital, highlighting the benefits of eliminating the remaining sources of airborne lead emissions.

WORK IN PROGRESS

"Principal Like Me: Principal–Student Demographic Match and Grade Retention" (Joint with Kendall J. Kennedy, Simon ter Meulen, and Umut Özek)

"Gained and Lost Classmates: The Spillover Effects of Grade Retention" (Joint with Kendall J. Kennedy, Simon ter Meulen, and Umut Özek)

"Retained and Reassigned? Grade Retention, Classroom Placement, and Paths to College, STEM, and Earnings" (Joint with Kendall J. Kennedy, Simon ter Meulen, and Umut Özek)

"Motivation or Stigma? Evaluating the Incentive Effects of Grade Retention Policy" (Joint with Kendall J. Kennedy and Simon ter Meulen)

"Access to Family Planning Services and Inequalities in Education and Labor Market Outcomes" (Joint with Riley Acton, James Flynn, Daniel Marthey, and Maranna Yoder)

"The Hidden Costs of Low-Level Lead Exposure: Evidence on Infant Health " (Joint with Tengda Gong)

"The Impacts of Light and Noise Exposure on Human Capital Formation: Evidence from Wind Farm Operation" (Joint with Thao Duong)

PRESENTATIONS

2026: NBER 2026 Summer Institute, RSF Pipeline Capstone Workshop & Conference, AEFP, PPCW 2026

2025: Allied Social Science Association (ASSA), ASHEcon, CeMENT Workshops, MidSouth Education Policy Workshop, APPAM Fall Research Conference, SEA

2024: Amherst College, Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, Miami University, University of Wisconsin-Whitewater, ND/Midwest Econ of Education Conference, Southern Economics Association conferences

2023: Southern Economics Association conferences, Western Economic Association International 98th Annual Conference, Eastern Economic Association Conferences, LBJ School Policy Research Workshop

2022: Southern Economics Association conferences, Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Western Economic Association International 97th Annual Conference, Midwest Economics Association

2021: Health Econ/Health Policy Mentoring Workshop

2020: Successfully Navigating Your Ph.D. Workshop

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record

Topics in Microeconomics (Spring 2027)

Public Economics (Fall 2025, Spring 2027)

Intermediate Microeconomic Theory (Spring 2026, Fall 2025, Spring 2025, Fall 2024, Summer 2022)

Econometrics Qualifier Camp (Ph.D. core), Summer 2022

Teaching Assistant

International Trade Theory & Policy, Fall 2023

Data Science for Economic and Social Issues, Spring 2023

Applied Micro-econometrics (Ph.D. level), Spring 2022

Econometrics 461, Fall 2021

Public Finance 412 (Spring 2020, Fall 2019, Spring 2019)

RESEARCH ASSISTANT

Texas A&M University, Prof. Barr, Summer and Fall 2021

HONORS AND AWARDS

Russell Sage Foundation Pipeline Grant (PI, $50,000), 2025-2026

The Institute for Humane Studies (IHS) Hayek Fund Scholars Grant Award ($500), 2022-2023

REFEREE SERVICE

American Economic Journal: Applied Economics (2); Journal of Public Economics (4); Journal of Policy Analysis and Management (2); Labor economics; Economics of Education Review (2); Journal of Development Economics; Economic Inquiry (2); Russell Sage Foundation Dissertation Grant (2)

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Program Committee, APPAM Fall Research Conference (2025)

SEMINAR COORDINATOR

Co-Chair, Economics Seminar Series, Miami University, 2026-Present

Student Brown Bag, Texas A& M Unviersity, Spring 2023 and Fall 2022

Professional Memberships

American Economic Association, American Society of Health Economists, Association of Environmental and Resource Economists, Southern Economics Association

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